Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 4.7 Guided Notes: Emotion

Unit 4: Social Psychology and Personality | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic4.7

Word Bank

Universal Emotions	*Facial-Feedback Hypothesis*	*Two-Factor Theory*
Broaden-and-Build Theory	*Succession*	*Simultaneous*
Cognitive Label	*Emotion*	*Cognitive Appraisal*
Elicitors	*Display Rules*	

1. The Mechanisms of Emotion

We've explored how we are motivated to act, but how do we feel while we are acting? In this final topic of Unit 4, we look at how we feel. _____, or affect, is a complex psychological process that is distinguished from reasoning or knowledge. Emotions reflect internal and external factors affecting an individual.

Psychologists have long debated exactly how and in what order we experience emotions. When you encounter an emotional stimulus, does your body react first, or do you feel the emotion first? Here are the primary theories that explain these mechanisms:

A quick note: You are not expected to know the names of the researchers who developed these theories. They are included since most textbooks still mention them by name. The AP curriculum states you only need to know these theories by the title listed below.

- _____ (Body First, Emotion Second): The James-Lange Theory proposes that our physiological response happens first, and our experience of emotion follows afterward. For example, you see a bear, your heart starts pounding (body response), and because of that physical change, you then feel afraid (emotion).
- _____ (Body and Emotion Together): The Cannon-Bard Theory argues that the physical arousal and the subjective experience of emotion happen together. In this view, seeing the bear triggers your pounding heart and the feeling of fear at the exact same time; one does not cause the other.
- The Role of Cognition (_____): The Schachter-Singer theory brings the brain's interpretation into the mix. It proposes that to experience a conscious emotion, you must have two things: physical arousal and a _____. You feel your heart pounding, you interpret the situation as “dangerous” because of the bear, and that interpretation combined with the physical arousal creates the emotion of fear.
- _____: This concept connects directly back to the idea of the body responding first. It suggests that the physical movement of your facial muscles (like smiling or frowning) actually happens before and directly influences your experience of emotion—occurring even before your brain completes its _____, the mental process of evaluating a situation to determine its emotional significance. For instance, if you force yourself to smile, that physical bodily response happens first, sending

signals to your brain that subsequently trigger the actual emotion of happiness. Research on this theory has produced mixed results.

Apply It: Which Emotion Mechanism?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	After noticing tears streaming down her face, a woman concludes that she must be sad.	
2	When a car swerves toward him, a cyclist's heart pounds and he feels terror at the very same instant, and neither one causes the other.	
3	A woman's heart races and her hands sweat, and because she is alone in a dark parking garage she interprets the situation as dangerous. Only the arousal and her interpretation together produce fear.	
4	A man's racing heart could signal fear or excitement, but his thought, "I'm just thrilled about tonight's concert," decides which emotion he feels.	
5	A teen holds a pencil between her teeth, which forces her mouth into a smile, and reports feeling slightly happier while reading cartoons.	
6	A student sizes up a surprise pop quiz as a manageable challenge rather than a disaster, and that mental evaluation shapes how nervous he feels.	

2. Broaden-and-Build Theory

Emotions don't just happen to us; they serve an evolutionary and cognitive purpose. The _____ of emotion proposes that positive emotional experiences tend to broaden awareness and encourage new actions and thoughts. When we are happy or joyful, we are more likely to explore, play, and connect with others. Conversely, negative emotions tend to reduce awareness and narrow thinking and action, which helps us focus on immediate threats (like escaping danger) but limits our creativity.

Graph note: Positive emotions broaden our awareness and encourage novel, exploratory thoughts and actions. Over time, this expanded mindset helps us build valuable personal resources (like new skills, resilience, and social connections), leading to greater overall well-being. That enhanced well-being then loops back and generates even more positive emotions, creating a continuous upward spiral.

Apply It: Which Theory Fits?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Overjoyed after winning a school prize, a student starts brainstorming creative new project ideas and teaming up with classmates she barely knows.	
2	Panicking about a looming deadline, a man can think of nothing except finishing the work, and he doesn't consider any creative alternatives. (This shows the other side of the same theory.)	

3. Expressing Emotion: Culture and Norms

Do people all over the world experience and express emotions the same way? Research has explored whether the expression of emotions is universally common.

- _____: Some emotions that may be commonly experienced across cultures include anger, disgust, sadness, happiness, surprise, and fear. However, research on the universality of emotions shows mixed results.
- _____ are the culturally learned norms that govern when, where, and how it's appropriate to express a given emotion. Along with _____ (the specific events or stimuli that trigger an emotional response), these norms can differ among cultures. They may regulate how people from different genders, ages, or socioeconomic classes within a culture can display and interpret emotions. (e.g., In some cultures, it is acceptable for men to express anger openly, while crying may be discouraged.)

Apply It: Culture and Emotion

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Researchers find that people in many different societies recognize the facial expressions for anger, fear, and surprise.	
2	In one workplace culture, employees are expected to hide frustration and smile politely in meetings, while in another it is normal to voice it openly.	
3	In one village, the arrival of the monsoon rains triggers festive joy, while in a drier region the same event triggers worry about flooding.	

4. Don't Trip Up! (AP Exam Exclusions)

⚠️ *Out of Scope – Specific Theory Names: In most textbooks you will likely see breakdowns of the theories of emotions by their actual names: James-Lange Theory, Cannon-Bard Theory, and Schachter-Singer Two-Factor Theory. Do not memorize these names! The College Board explicitly states: Specific names of theories of emotion are outside the scope of the AP Psychology Exam. Instead, focus purely on the mechanisms (e.g., understanding the debate between physiological response happening in succession vs. simultaneously).*

📺 *Video Notes: "Feeling All the Feels" (Crash Course Psychology #25)*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words. The video names the researchers behind each theory, but remember that you don't need to know those names for the AP Exam. The video also covers some ideas that aren't on the page (such as the brain's "high road" and "low road"), and the page covers some that the video doesn't (such as the facial-feedback hypothesis, broaden-and-build theory, and display rules).

1. How does the video define emotion, and what three components does it say emotions involve? Use its footsteps example.

2. The video describes two ideas about the order of body reactions and emotion. What is each idea, and what objection led to the second?

3. How does the video explain the two-factor idea and the spillover effect, and what did the epinephrine experiment find?

4. What does the video say about emotional reactions that happen before thinking, and how do the brain's high road and low road differ?

5. What do the sympathetic and parasympathetic divisions do during emotion, and what does the video mean by optimal arousal?

6. How similar are the body's signals across different emotions, according to the video, and what differences does it say can show up?

5. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A hiker rounds a corner and comes face to face with a bear. His heart begins pounding, and he then consciously interprets this specific situation as "dangerous" because of the bear's presence; only once he has both this physical arousal and this specific cognitive label does he actually experience the conscious emotion of fear. This mechanism, requiring both physical arousal and an interpretive label to form an emotion, is called:

- **A.** Simultaneous Processing
- **B.** Broaden-and-Build Theory
- **C.** Succession
- **D.** The Two-Factor Model

2. A woman forces herself to hold a big, wide smile on her face for two full minutes during a stressful morning, even though she doesn't feel happy at all, and she is surprised to notice that her mood genuinely begins to lift and feel lighter shortly afterward. This concept, suggesting that facial muscle movements can directly influence and even happen before the actual experience of an emotion, is called the:

- **A.** Broaden-and-Build Theory
- **B.** Facial-Feedback Hypothesis
- **C.** Display Rules
- **D.** Two-Factor Model

3. Before a person can consciously determine whether a specific situation is exciting, threatening, or completely neutral, their brain must first go through a distinct mental process of evaluating that situation to figure out its emotional significance. This specific mental evaluation process is called:

- **A.** Cognitive Appraisal
- **B.** Display Rules
- **C.** The Facial-Feedback Hypothesis
- **D.** An Elicitor

4. After receiving unexpectedly wonderful news, a woman feels a genuine surge of pure joy, and this positive emotion makes her suddenly want to call an old friend she hasn't spoken to in years, try a new hobby she's been curious about, and generally explore new opportunities she wouldn't have considered otherwise. This theory, which explains how positive emotions expand awareness and encourage new thoughts and actions, is called:

- **A.** Broaden-and-Build Theory
- **B.** Sensation-Seeking Theory
- **C.** Display Rules
- **D.** The Two-Factor Model

5. In a certain culture, it is considered completely socially acceptable and even expected for men to openly express anger in public settings, but boys and men are simultaneously taught from a young age to suppress and hide any tears or visible sadness. These culturally learned norms about when, where, and how it is appropriate to express a given emotion are called:

- **A.** Cognitive Appraisal
- **B.** Elicitors
- **C.** Display Rules
- **D.** Universal Emotions

6. For one particular man, the specific sight of a spider crawling across the floor is the exact stimulus that consistently triggers his intense feeling of fear every single time, while other people might not have any emotional reaction to a spider at all. This specific event or stimulus that triggers an emotional response is called an:

- **A.** Cognitive Appraisal
- **B.** Elicitor
- **C.** Display Rule
- **D.** Instinct

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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